days later, I happened to be in the lift when my father looked intently at the attendant and asked him if he knew him from somewhere.

The elevator attendant stiffened to attention, but before he could reply, my father had recognized him. ‘Har Narayan?’ he asked tentatively.

The soldier practically fell into his arms, overwhelmed. Too proud to introduce himself, he had waited for his company officer from the Walong days in NEFA to recognize him. One of the survivors of Nam Ka Chu, Har Narayan had been wounded and taken prisoner. By the time he was repatriated along with the others, he had lost all his toes—they had had to be amputated by Chinese doctors because of frostbite.

After that first encounter a steady stream of retired soldiers started to come and meet my father. A few days later, Har Narayan arrived with a JCO (junior commissioned officer) whose name I cannot recall. Soon enough, the three men were deep in discussion about the NEFA days, talking of comrades who had been so much a part of their lives. After having a couple of stiff rums prepared by the bartender (me), the subedar suddenly looked searchingly at my father and asked, ‘Why did it happen, saab?’ He then added: ‘You remember what was said by General Thorat? You were there,’ he said simply.

Seventeen years after the event, this was a name I hadn’t heard before, certainly not in the context of what had happened in 1962. After the JCO and Har Narayan had left, I asked my father what all that was about. Lieutenant General S. P. P. Thorat, he said, was the man everybody expected to succeed General K.S. Thimayya as the army chief. That hadn’t happened because the defence minister, V. K. Krishna Menon, disliked Thorat and had ensured that Prime Minister Nehru sent the general home. Pran Thapar was appointed chief instead. In early 1960, Thorat, at the time, the Eastern Army Commander, had visited the battalion that was preparing the defences at Walong. The general had been taken around the location and was briefed by Lieutenant Colonel Maha Singh Rikh. My father and the JCO who had visited us had been deputed to escort the general as his liaison team, so they had both been privy to the conversation between the army commander and the commanding officer (CO), Rikh. After making a few suggestions about the siting of certain bunkers and defensive positions, Thorat had stated quite categorically, ‘You have three years. The Chinese will come down this axis in October-November 1962. They will definitely come.’